The report provided a template for leadership tours and agitations. ‘Agitate or Vegitate [sic]’, it declared. ‘Whether it is true or not with regard to other institutions or organisations working in other fields, it is quite true for parties and much more so to a party like BJP.’[117]

It will not be an exaggeration to say that the intellectual roots of Shah and Modi’s leadership styles lie in these recommendations. In 2014, the BJP reinvented its tradition of pravaas—outstation trips by its leaders—mandating that all national office-bearers must visit nine states in one year. They would do so by rotation, ensuring that all states were covered. Amit Shah, for example, started his own pravaas from Naxalbari, where an armed revolt in the 1960s gave the Naxal movement its name. Between August 2014 and 2018, as party president, he had addressed 1,027 party organisation programmes, travelling 7,90,000 km or 519 km a day on average.[118] In his first year and a half as president (August 2014 to end 2015), he stayed overnight on 102 occasions in various states.[119] This data indicates the heavy emphasis that the BJP’s top brass puts on organisational work, compared to its national rival, the Congress.

In conclusion, the 1985 report extolled the value of the ‘Party office’ as the ‘nerve centre of the Party activities’ recommending that a ‘well-equipped, efficient, effective functioning office is a must at national level, State level and district level’. In particular, it found that the BJP had no offices in a large number of Indian districts. Hence, it laid down: ‘Party offices in a manner in which we require should be set up in all the districts throughout the country within a year.’[120] Again, the roots of Amit Shah’s district office building drive can be traced back to this three-decades-old document. Although it took the BJP another three decades to follow through on the recommendations—only after it came to power under Modi, and had the resources to do so—the template used, with some modern modifications, was rooted in the party’s learnings in its earliest years.

The role of party structure as a tool of political mobilisation is relatively understudied in India. But, in a rapidly urbanising and demographically young India, it should not be underestimated. Some of the BJP’s electoral successes in recent years accrue as much to this grassroots work as to its larger ideological shifts. As Amit Shah